



RUGGED WILDERNESS

Located in the Blue Mountains, the Grose Valley is a wilderness area featuring a combination of dry open forest with dramatic gorges, cliffs, and canyons.



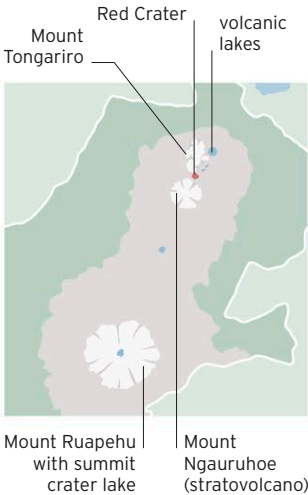
Tongariro Volcanic Park

A volcanic wonderland in the center of New Zealand's North Island

Tongariro is a large national park in New Zealand centered on three active stratovolcanoes. These are Mount Tongariro, which has a complicated structure consisting of at least 12 overlapping volcanic cones and numerous craters; Ngauruhoe, a single, highly symmetrical volcanic cone; and Ruapehu, the largest active volcano in New Zealand. The summits of Ngauruhoe and Ruapehu—which at 9,177 ft (2,797 m) is the highest point on the North Island—are considered sacred by the local Maori people. The whole park, which is dominated by volcanic features such as ancient craters and solidified lava flows, has a stark beauty.

TONGARIRO'S VOLCANOES

Much of the park is volcanic terrain (gray) surrounded by forested areas (green). The main concentration of small volcanic features lies at the northern end, around Mount Tongariro, while Ruapehu, which tends to produce a large eruption every 50 years, looms in the south.



▼ **CRATERS AND LAKES**
In this view of Tongariro volcano, several craters and lakes are visible. The lake colors come from minerals leached out of surrounding rocks.



HOW THE AUSTRALIAN ALPS FORMED

The history of the Great Dividing Range is very complex, but one part of it, the Australian Alps, is theorized to have originated when a microcontinent called Zealandia (see pp.272-73) rifted away from southeastern Australia. Today, Zealandia is mostly submerged (the parts above land are New Zealand), while the rift margin on the Australian side has been eroded down to form the Australian Alps.

